dawning as much on the larger Persianate world as on the emerging Shansabani clan.[62]

Emergence into "History"

The oft-quoted anecdote in Juzjani's *Ṭabaqat* of the inter-clan competition between the Shansabanis' mythical progenitor Amir Banji ibn Naharan and another important personage of Ghur called Shish ibn Bahram appears to be a legendary "origin myth" more than reportage of fact. The story's basic plot consists of the rivalrous Ghuri chieftains seeking mediation by the great 'Abbasid Caliph Harun al-Rashid (r. AH 169–193/786–809 CE) himself, based at his magnificent court in Baghdad. Juzjani's tale also described the intercession on behalf of Banji by a Jewish merchant: this figure's function as a synecdoche of the Jewish communities of Afghanistan has already been borne out by the epigraphical, architectural, and archaeological evidence gradually emerging from the region over the last century of surveys and documentation, illuminating its socio-economic history.[63] This "origin myth," then, may hold further historical kernels, akin to the noted confessional and professional affiliation of one of the protagonists, *viz.* the Jewish merchant.

In essence, Juzjani's story was a Pygmalion-like tale of the advantages of transformation from provincialism to urbanity. Both the mentioned Ghuri chiefs were rough and uncouth in dress and manner, given their origins in a remote area supposedly out of the reach of the refinements of Islamicate civilization – arguably at one of its apogees by the ninth century; both of them were therefore unfit to enter the caliph's court. But Banji was friendly with a Jewish merchant from Ghur, cosmopolitan and wise in the ways of the world due to his own far-reaching travels in pursuit of commerce. Heeding his advice on dress and behavior, Banji came into the caliph's presence much better prepared than his rival Shish. In Harun al-Rashid's arbitration, Shish ibn Bahram was awarded military command over Ghur, while Banji was awarded the region's governing authority and the title of *amir* – the latter clearly the superior position and presumably the greater reward for Banji's ability to adapt to the cultured ways of comportment and overall self-presentation prevailing at the caliph's glittering court.[64]

Juzjani's pithy anecdote certainly mythologized the age-old and continuing rivalry between the Shansabanis and their collateral relations the Shishanis, resurfacing periodically even after the two lines were allied by marriage (see esp. Chapter 4). More compellingly, it hinted at the Shansabanis' origins in central Afghanistan's nomad–urban continuum of the early second millennium CE (continuing into modern times). But ultimately, I propose that the story encapsulated the Shansabanis' – and perhaps also the Shishanis' – own larger process of transformation